

range of interests and activities, and was content to be single, but she knew it was up to her to take care of her own finances.

Around that time, several churches in their town got together and invited a financial expert to talk about the Bible's teaching on money. Beth attended, and was surprised to learn that the Bible said so much about money and its management. She took the expert's advice on setting up a budget and actually did better for about a year. She nearly stopped charging and tried, with some success, to stay within her budget. However, there was no personal accountability, and she soon fell back into her old habits.

Then she was involved in a minor traffic accident. Though no one was hurt, the repairs were costly, and she had to use her rent money to pay the five hundred dollar deductible. She then had to put off her cell phone and a couple of utility bills to pay the rent, putting her behind for a couple of months. Without savings to fall back on and with her credit cards maxed out, she grew panicky that she was in a hole she'd never get out of.

By now Beth understood that her reluctance to deny herself materially was a result of her family's struggles after her father's death. She hadn't liked having to do without when she perceived that her friends could have anything they wanted. She hadn't liked feeling different. As an adult, she enjoyed supporting herself and being successful in her career, but she carried that determination to enjoy things money could buy with her, and her lack of self-control had gotten her into trouble. Now she was tired of living with anxiety—not from fear of not having things as nice as her friends, but real fear of never getting out of the cycle of debt.